

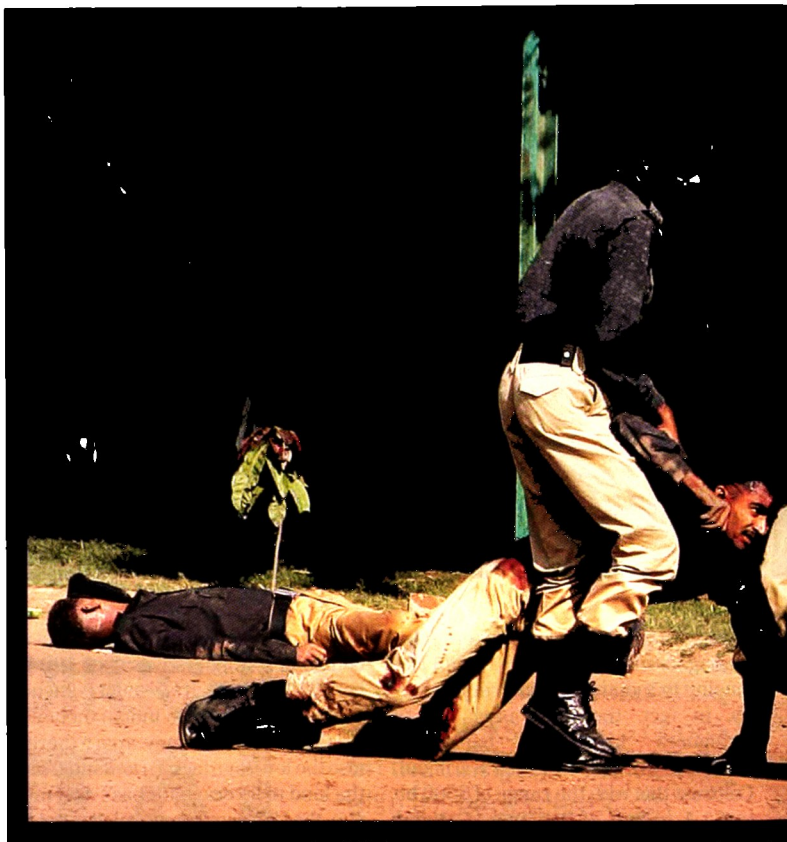
The Crimson TIDE

As terrorists strike at will, the war against rising militancy in Pakistan becomes a choice between the devil and the deep sea for the Zardari Government

| By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi |

If any further proof was needed about the precarious security environment Pakistan is faced with, the audacious fidayeen attack on the Manawan Police Training School on March 30 provided it. Located on the outskirts of Lahore and only a few miles away from the Wagah border, the school was stormed by at least seven militants at about 7 a.m. while about 850 police recruits and instructors were involved in morning exercises on the school's parade grounds. Armed with rifles and grenades, the attackers shot policemen at random and held off police, paramilitary and army reinforcements for about eight hours before the law enforcement agencies regained control. Four of the attackers were dead—three having blown themselves up to avoid arrests—and three had been arrested alive, while eight others, including five young police recruits and two instructors had been killed, and 92 injured.

Critics of the Government and the media were quick to raise questions about the lax security at the police centre, despite apparently specific warnings from intelligence that such an attack was imminent at high profile targets including police installations. However, there was also a palpable sense of relief among ordinary Pakistanis that the incident had been resolved within a few hours and that casualties had turned out to be much lower than expected. With the brutal long-drawn-out attack on Mumbai in mind, and despair lingering over the clean getaway of those who had attacked the Sri Lankan cricket team in Lahore earlier in the month, for the first time Pakistanis felt that they might have a chance against the rising tide of extremism. The



celebration by police forces once they regained control over the Manawan Centre, summed up the public mood in a sense.

But of course, the latest attack—coming after a failed attempt by a suicide bomber to target Special Branch offices in Islamabad on March 23—does raise serious questions about the spread of militancy in Pakistan, and its regional linkages. For instance, Hijratullah, one of those arrested at Manawan, has turned out to be an Afghan national hailing from

Paktika province. According to government interrogators, he has confessed that the planning for the operation was done in South Waziristan in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) under the guidance of Baitullah Mehsud, the leader of Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan and one of Pakistan's most wanted militants, and his nominated heir, Qari Hussain Mehsud.

Baitullah Mehsud, who also has a \$5-million bounty on his head from the United States Government and is